The obligatory exit interview.

The chosen reporter asked what I'd done in Afghanistan.

I told him.

He asked if I'd fired on the enemy.

What? Yes.

His head went back. Surprised.

What did he think we were doing over here? Selling magazine subscriptions?

He asked if I'd killed anyone.

Yes…

Again, surprised.

I tried to explain: *It's a war, mate, you know?*

The conversation came around to the press. I told the reporter that I thought the British press was crap, particularly with regard to my brother and sister-in-law, who'd just announced that they were pregnant, and were subsequently being besieged.

They deserve to have their baby in peace, I said.

I admitted that my father had begged me to stop thinking about the press, to not read the papers. I admitted that I felt guilty every time I did, because it made me complicit. *Everyone's guilty for buying the newspapers. But hopefully no one actually believes what's in them.*

But of course they did. People did believe, and that was the whole problem. Britons, among the most literate people on the planet, were also the most credulous. Even if they didn't believe every word, there was always that residue of wonder. *Hmm, where there's smoke there must be fire…*Even if a falsehood was disproved, debunked beyond all doubt, that residue of initial belief remained.

Especially if the falsehood was negative. Of all human biases, "negativity bias" is the most indelible. It's baked into our brains. Privilege the negative, prioritize the negative—that's how our ancestors survived. That's what the bloody papers count on, I wanted to say.

But didn't. It wasn't that kind of discussion. Wasn't a discussion at all. The reporter was keen to move on, to ask about Vegas.